

moving parts that we had to cut a lot of corners to get it done on time. I won't mince words: the first version was terrible. We spent endless hours arguing about which bugs to fix and which we could live with, which features to cut and which to try to cram in. It was a wonderful and terrifying time: we were full of hope about the possibilities for success and full of fear about the consequences of shipping a bad product.

Personally, I was worried that the low quality of the product would tarnish my reputation as an engineer. People would think I didn't know how to build a quality product. All of us feared tarnishing the IMVU brand; after all, we were charging people money for a product that didn't work very well. We all envisioned the damning newspaper headlines: "Inept Entrepreneurs Build Dreadful Product."

As launch day approached, our fears escalated. In our situation, many entrepreneurial teams give in to fear and postpone the launch date. Although I understand this impulse, I am glad we persevered, since delay prevents many startups from getting the feedback they need. Our previous failures made us more afraid of another, even worse, outcome than shipping a bad product: building something that nobody wants. And so, teeth clenched and apologies at the ready, we released our product to the public.

Launch

And then—nothing happened! It turned out that our fears were unfounded, because nobody even tried our product. At first I was relieved because at least nobody was finding out how bad the product was, but soon that gave way to serious frustration. After all the hours we had spent arguing about which features to include and which bugs to fix, our value proposition was so far off that customers weren't getting far enough into the experience to find out how bad our design choices were. Customers wouldn't even download our product.

Over the ensuing weeks and months, we labored to make the